NORTHSTAR
DIGITAL SERVICES

Performance Management Guidelines

MANAGER • HR

Policy document • Version 1.0 • Effective date: 15 October 2026

Prepared as synthetic content for a role-based retrieval-augmented generation (RAG) demonstration. This document is not an actual company policy.

Access classification: MANAGER • HR

1. Setting expectations and collecting evidence

Policy owner: HR Operations

Purpose

These guidelines standardize performance planning, feedback and evaluation for managers at the fictional Northstar Digital Services.

Performance dimensions

Evaluate role-relevant outcomes, work quality, reliability, collaboration, customer impact, learning and demonstration of company values. Weightings should reflect the role and be communicated in advance.

Goal setting

At the start of a review period, agree on a small number of measurable goals, expected behaviours, milestones and available support. Goals should be realistic, within the employee's influence and aligned with team priorities.

Evidence standard

Use specific examples from the review period, not isolated impressions or recent events alone. Distinguish observed facts from interpretation and give the employee a chance to provide context.

Fairness and bias

Do not use protected characteristics, leave-taking, disability-related absence or personal similarity as a basis for ratings. Consider whether workload, resources, role scope and changing priorities affected results.

Ongoing feedback

Provide feedback close to the event, explain the impact and agree on a next step. Formal review meetings should not be the first time an employee learns about a significant concern.

2. Review and calibration process

Policy owner: HR Operations

Preparation

Review goals, project outcomes, agreed metrics, documented feedback and the employee's self-assessment if used. Identify missing evidence and avoid unsupported conclusions.

Review conversation

Discuss achievements, areas for improvement, career interests and support needed. Invite the employee's perspective and summarize agreements, owners and dates.

Rating definitions

If a rating scale is used, define each level with observable standards. For example, 'meets expectations' means consistently delivering the agreed requirements for the role; it should not mean 'average person' or 'no problems ever'.

Calibration

Calibration can help teams apply standards consistently, but it must not become an arbitrary quota exercise. Changes to a proposed rating should be supported by role-relevant evidence and documented rationale.

Disagreement

Record the employee's comments where the process allows. Explain any review or appeal route and refer procedural disputes or allegations of bias to HR.

Promotion readiness

Strong performance in the current role is relevant but not automatically sufficient for promotion. Consider scope, sustained impact, skills required for the next level and the published promotion framework.

Confidentiality

Share performance records only with authorized people who need them for management or HR duties. Do not discuss ratings in public team channels.

3. Development, improvement and documentation

Policy owner: HR Operations

Development plans

Agree on skills to build, practice opportunities, learning resources, a target date and how progress will be assessed. Development should be actionable rather than a generic instruction to 'communicate better'.

Performance concerns

Describe the gap between expected and observed work, give concrete examples, ask about barriers and agree on support and follow-up. Consult HR before formal corrective action.

Improvement plans

A formal performance improvement plan should specify expectations, measurable milestones, reasonable timeframes, check-in frequency, support available and potential consequences. HR should review the plan before it is issued.

Documentation

Write factual, respectful notes. Include dates, expectations, evidence, employee response, support offered and agreed actions. Avoid speculation, medical details and inflammatory language.

Manager checklist

Were expectations clear? Is evidence representative? Did the employee have a chance to respond? Were resources and context considered? Is the rating consistent with the definitions? Has HR reviewed sensitive matters?

Common errors

Avoid recency bias, halo or horns effects, comparing employees with different scopes without adjustment, changing goals retroactively and treating disagreement as poor attitude.

Ownership

HR owns the review cycle and rating framework. Managers are accountable for timely, evidence-based and respectful conversations.